

# Active and Passive Voice Matrix

A Precision Grammar Blueprint for Structural Transformations, Tense Adjustments, and Syntactic Rules

In English grammar, **Voice** denotes the relationship between the action expressed by the verb and the participant identified by the subject. Understanding voice allows writers to shift emphasis strategically between the performer of an action and the recipient of that action.

## 1. CORE CONCEPTS & STRUCTURAL MECHANICS

The distinction between Active and Passive voice relies completely on whether the grammatical subject functions as the *agent* (doer) or the *patient* (receiver) of the action:

### Active Voice (Subject Performs)

The subject performs the action directly. It follows a direct, forward-moving syntax that is clear, concise, and energetic.

**Subject + Verb + Object**

**Example:** *The chef prepared the meal.*

### Passive Voice (Subject Receives)

The subject receives the action. The original object is elevated to the subject slot, emphasizing the target or outcome of the action.

**Object + Be Verb + V3 + by + Subject**

**Example:** *The meal was prepared by the chef.*

## 2. THE CORE RULES OF TRANSFORMATION

To convert an active sentence into a passive sentence systematically, five sequential structural rules must be applied:

- Object Swap:** Identify the direct object of the active sentence and place it into the subject slot of the passive sentence.
- Auxiliary Assignment:** Introduce the appropriate form of the auxiliary verb "to be" matching the primary tense of the active verb.
- Verb Modification:** Convert the principal active verb into its **Past Participle (V3)** form.
- Agent Introduction:** Insert the preposition "by" before the original doer (agent) of the action.
- Pronoun Case Shift:** If subjects/objects are pronouns, shift them between Subjective and Objective cases seamlessly.

| Subjective Pronoun Case (Active Subject) | Objective Pronoun Case (Passive Agent Object) |
|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| I / We                                   | me / us                                       |
| You / It                                 | you / it (No morphological case change)       |
| He / She / They                          | him / her / them                              |

## 3. THE TRANSITIVE VERB CONSTRAINT

An active sentence can **only** be converted to the passive voice if it contains a **Transitive Verb** (a verb that takes a direct object). Intransitive verbs cannot be mapped into passive syntax because they lack an object to promote to the subject position.

- Transitive (Convertible):** "She wrote a book." → "A book was written by her."
- Intransitive (Non-Convertible):** "The baby slept soundly." or "He arrived early." → **No Passive Form possible.**

## 4. SYSTEMATIC TENSE CONVERSION MATRIX

The matrix below outlines how the structural formula adapts across active and passive structures for all standard tenses:

| Tense / Aspect  | Active Formula & Exemplar                                                    | Passive Formula & Exemplar                                                                      |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Simple Present  | <b>S + V1 (+s/es) + O</b><br>He <b>delivers</b> the packages.                | <b>O + am/is/are + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>are delivered</b> by him.                 |
| Simple Past     | <b>S + V2 + O</b><br>He <b>delivered</b> the packages.                       | <b>O + was/were + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>were delivered</b> by him.                 |
| Simple Future   | <b>S + will + V1 + O</b><br>He <b>will deliver</b> the packages.             | <b>O + will be + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>will be delivered</b> by him.               |
| Present Cont.   | <b>S + am/is/are + V1+ing + O</b><br>He <b>is delivering</b> the packages.   | <b>O + am/is/are + being + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>are being delivered</b> by him.   |
| Past Cont.      | <b>S + was/were + V1+ing + O</b><br>He <b>was delivering</b> the packages.   | <b>O + was/were + being + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>were being delivered</b> by him.   |
| Present Perfect | <b>S + have/has + V3 + O</b><br>He <b>has delivered</b> the packages.        | <b>O + have/has + been + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>have been delivered</b> by him.     |
| Past Perfect    | <b>S + had + V3 + O</b><br>He <b>had delivered</b> the packages.             | <b>O + had + been + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>had been delivered</b> by him.           |
| Future Perfect  | <b>S + will have + V3 + O</b><br>He <b>will have delivered</b> the packages. | <b>O + will have been + V3 + by + S</b><br>The packages <b>will have been delivered</b> by him. |

**Exclusion Note (Non-Passive Formations):** Continuous Perfect tenses (Present/Past/Future Perfect Continuous) and the Future Continuous tense are traditionally **never used** in the passive voice due to awkward, repetitive auxiliary nesting (e.g., "*will be being written*").

## 5. ADVANCED STRUCTURAL MODIFICATIONS

Specific syntactical sentence formats require unique structural adjustments outside standard rules:

### A. Interrogative Sentences (Questions)

Questions maintain their interrogative structure when converted, but helping verbs align with the newly promoted passive subject:

- **Active (Does/Did):** "*Did Alex design the logo?*" → **Passive:** "*Was the logo designed by Alex?*"
- **Active (Who):** "*Who broke the glass?*" → **Passive (By whom):** "*By whom was the glass broken?*"

### B. Imperative Sentences (Commands & Requests)

Commands or orders utilize the formula structure containing the word "**Let**" when converted:

**Formula:** **Let + Object + be + V3**

**Active Command:** "*Shut the door.*" → **Passive:** "*Let the door be shut.*"

**Active Request:** "*Please help me.*" → **Passive:** "*You are requested to help me.*"

### C. Sentences with Dual (Ditransitive) Objects

When an active verb takes both a **Direct Object (DO)** and an **Indirect Object (IO)**, either can be promoted, yielding two correct passive outputs:

- **Active Base:** "*The manager gave me (IO) a bonus (DO).*"
- **Passive Option 1 (IO promoted):** "*I was given a bonus by the manager.*" (Preferred style)
- **Passive Option 2 (DO promoted):** "*A bonus was given to me by the manager.*"

D. Omission of the Agent (By-Object)

The agent component (*"by someone"*) is omitted if the actor is unknown, vague, obvious, or unimportant to the core information:

- **Active:** *"Someone stole my wallet."* → **Passive:** *"My wallet was stolen."* (Agent omitted)
- **Active:** *"The police arrested the suspect."* → **Passive:** *"The suspect was arrested."*